3 Communication Challenges in a Diverse, Global Marketplace

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you will be able to

1. Discuss the opportunities and challenges of intercultural communication.
2. Define cultural competency, and explain the influence of culture on business communication.
3. Explain the importance of recognizing cultural variations, and list eight key dimensions of cultural diversity.
4. List four general guidelines for adapting to any business culture.
5. Identify six steps you can take to improve your intercultural communication skills.

COMMUNICATION CLOSE-UP AT Siemens AG

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According to Siemens, the future needs ideas, innovations, sustainability, curiosity, ambition, values, and answers. The German multinational conglomerate knows that its unique strength as a global industrial powerhouse lies in the creative potential and dedication of its 385,000 employees, spread across more than 200 countries. As the largest manufacturing and electronics company in Europe, with offices, warehouses, or research and development facilities in almost every country in the world, Siemens's employees are as global as its locations. In Germany alone, employees represent over 125 nations. The internationality of the workforce is reflected in all regions and on all levels; the global management team consists of employees from over 107 countries.

Siemens values diversity in its workforce through the inclusion and collaboration of different perspectives, backgrounds, ages, levels of experience, and expertise across all organizational levels. Diversity is seen as an important means of strengthening the company's innovative capacity. Diverse teams increase the wealth of ideas within the company, unleashing the potential of Siemens's employees, thus directly contributing to the success of its business.

Managers are expected to give continuous support to their employees in a friendly and open workplace where they can discuss their thoughts and ideas openly with colleagues across the world. They are actively encouraged to gain international experience and discover other countries through a permanent position or a temporary assignment.

In 2015, in her TED^{X}Berlin talk titled "Using the Power of Being Different," Janina Kugel, a former personnel manager at Siemens, urged potential leaders to adapt to and understand different perspectives: if you want to manage a global organization, you need to listen to people. Kugel became a champion of diversity as she came to recognize that there cannot be a single culture in a company that operates in more



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At Seimens, diversity of perspectives, expertise, backgrounds, ages, and levels of experience is considered vital to the company's innovative capacity.

than 200 countries—Siemens Chile has a different culture than Siemens China, and the latter in turn has a different culture than Siemens Germany.

In its Diversity Fact Sheets, Siemens shows how all genders contribute to business success. The company has strived to create significantly more employment opportunities for women, from the board level to every workplace, thus also contributing to the UN's "Gender Balance" sustainable development goal. In 2016, Siemens signed the United Nations Women's Empowerment Principles to strengthen the position of women in the company, which was the first worldwide initiative focused on directly promoting and strengthening women in business.

According to Maria Ferraro, Siemens' new chief diversity officer, diversity and inclusion are good qualities to encourage for their own sake, but they are also a vital part of Siemens's success. Teams that are diverse and inclusive tend to breed greater success because they encourage creativity and innovation.[1]

Understanding the Opportunities and Challenges of Communication in a Diverse World

1 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Discuss the opportunities and challenges of intercultural communication.

Diversity includes all the characteristics that define people as individuals.

Intercultural communication is the process of sending and receiving messages between people whose cultural backgrounds could lead them to interpret verbal and nonverbal signs differently.

Siemens AG (profiled in the chapter-opening Close-Up) illustrates diversity in an organization's workforce and collaboration of different thinking across all organizational levels. Although the concept is often framed in terms of race or gender, a broader and more useful definition of **diversity** includes "all the characteristics and experiences that define each of us as individuals."[2] Some aspects of diversity, such as race and age, are inherent. Others, such as work history, language, religion, cultural immersion, and education, are acquired through life experience.[3] Together, these characteristics and experiences can have a profound effect on the way businesspeople communicate.

Intercultural communication is the process of sending and receiving messages between people whose cultural backgrounds could lead them to interpret verbal and nonverbal signs differently. Every attempt to send and receive messages is influenced by culture, so to communicate successfully, you need a basic grasp of the cultural differences you may encounter and how you should handle them. Efforts to recognize and bridge cultural differences will open up business opportunities throughout the world and maximize the contributions of all the employees in a diverse workforce.

THE OPPORTUNITIES IN A GLOBAL MARKETPLACE

You will communicate with people from many other cultures throughout your career.

Chances are good that you'll be working across international borders sometime in your career. Thanks to communication and transportation technologies, natural boundaries and national borders are no longer the impassable barriers they once were. Local markets are opening to worldwide competition as businesses of all sizes look for new growth opportunities outside their own countries. Thousands of U.S. businesses depend on exports for significant portions of their revenues. If you work in one of these companies, you may well be called on to visit or at least communicate with a wide variety of people who speak languages other than English and who live in cultures quite different from what you're used to.

THE ADVANTAGES OF A DIVERSE WORKFORCE

The diversity of today's workforce brings distinct advantages to businesses:

- A broader range of views and ideas
- A better understanding of diverse, fragmented markets
- A broader pool of talent from which to recruit

Even if you never visit another country or transact business on a global scale, you will interact with colleagues from a variety of cultures, with a wide range of characteristics and life experiences. Over the past few decades, many innovative companies have changed the way they approach diversity, from seeing it as a legal requirement (providing equal opportunities for all) to seeing it as a strategic opportunity. Smart business leaders recognize the competitive advantages of a diverse workforce that offers a broader spectrum of viewpoints and ideas, helps businesses understand and identify with diverse markets, and enables companies to benefit from a wider range of employee talents.[4] Numerous studies show a correlation between company performance and workforce diversity.[5]

THE CHALLENGES OF INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION

A company's cultural diversity affects how its business messages are conceived, composed, delivered, received, and interpreted.

Today's increasingly diverse workforce encompasses a wide range of skills, traditions, backgrounds, experiences, outlooks, and attitudes toward work—all of which can affect communication in the workplace. Supervisors face the challenge of connecting with these diverse employees, motivating them, and fostering cooperation and harmony among them. Teams face the challenge of working together closely, and companies are challenged to coexist peacefully with business partners and with the community as a whole.

Culture influences everything about communication, including

- Language
- Nonverbal signals
- Word meaning
- Time and space issues
- Rules of human relationships

The interaction of culture and communication is so pervasive that separating the two is virtually impossible. The way you communicate is deeply influenced by the culture in which you were raised. The meaning of words, the significance of gestures, the importance of time and space, the rules of human relationships—these and many other aspects of communication are defined by culture. To a large degree, your culture influences the way you think, which naturally affects the way you communicate as both a sender and a receiver.[6] Intercultural communication is much more complicated than simply matching language between sender and receiver; it goes beyond words to beliefs, values, and emotions.

Your instinct is to encode messages using the assumptions of *your* culture, but members of your audience decode messages according to the assumptions of *their* culture.

Elements of human diversity can affect communication at every stage of the communication process, from the ideas a person deems important enough to share to the habits and expectations of giving feedback. In particular, your instinct is to encode messages using the assumptions of *your* culture. However, members of your audience decode your messages according to the assumptions of *their* culture. Thinking back to Figure 1.6's illustration of how shared experience affects understanding, you can see how the further two cultures are apart, the more challenging it can be to transfer messages and meaning successfully.

Throughout this chapter, you'll see examples of how communication styles and habits vary from one culture to another. These examples are intended to illustrate the major themes of intercultural communication, not to give an exhaustive list of styles and habits of any particular culture. With an understanding of these major themes, you'll be prepared to explore the specifics of any culture.

Developing Cultural Competency

2 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Define cultural competency, and explain the influence of culture on business communication.

Cultural competency includes appreciation for cultural differences that affect communication and the ability to adjust one's communication style to match the situation.

Cultural competency includes an appreciation for cultural differences that affect communication and the ability to adjust one's communication style to ensure that efforts to send and receive messages across cultural boundaries are successful. In other words, it requires a combination of attitude, knowledge, and skills.[7]

The good news is that you're already an expert in culture, at least in the culture in which you grew up. You understand how your society works, how people are expected to communicate, what common gestures and facial expressions mean, and so on. The bad news is that because you're such an expert in your own culture, your communication is largely automatic; that is, you rarely stop to think about the communication rules you're following. An important step toward successful intercultural communication is becoming more aware of these rules and of the way they influence your communication.

UNDERSTANDING THE CONCEPT OF CULTURE

Culture is a shared system of symbols, beliefs, attitudes, values, expectations, and behavior norms.

Culture is a shared system of symbols, beliefs, attitudes, values, expectations, and norms for behavior. All people belong to multiple cultures that influence their beliefs and behaviors to varying degrees. In addition to the culture you share with all the people who live in your own country, you belong to other cultural groups, sometimes referred to as *subcultures*, including an ethnic group, possibly a religious group, maybe a political party, and perhaps a profession that has its own special language and customs. With its large population and long history of immigration, the United States is home to a vast array of cultures.

Members of every culture tend to have similar assumptions about how people should think, behave, and communicate.

Members of a given culture tend to have similar assumptions about how people should think, behave, and communicate, and they tend to act on those assumptions in much the same way. Cultures can vary in their rate of change, degree of complexity, and tolerance toward outsiders. These differences affect the level of trust and openness you can achieve when communicating with people of other cultures.

You learn culture both directly (by being instructed) and indirectly (by observing others).

People learn culture directly and indirectly from other members of their group. As you grow up in a culture, you are taught by the group's members who you are and how best to function in that culture. Sometimes you are explicitly told which behaviors are acceptable; at other times you learn by observing which values work best in a particular group. Over time, the influences of that culture tend to become *automatic*, in that you follow them without thinking about them.

Cultures tend to offer views of life that are both *coherent* (internally logical) and *complete* (able to answer all of life's big questions).

In addition to being automatic, culture tends to be *coherent*; that is, a culture appears to be fairly logical and consistent when viewed from the inside. Certain norms within a culture may not make sense to someone outside the culture, but they probably make sense to those inside. Such coherence generally helps a culture function more smoothly internally, but it can create disharmony between cultures that don't view the world in the same way.

Finally, cultures tend to be complete in the sense that they provide their members with most of the answers to life's big questions. This idea of completeness dulls or even suppresses curiosity about life in other cultures. Not surprisingly, such completeness can complicate communication with other cultures.[8]

OVERCOMING ETHNOCENTRISM AND STEREOTYPING

Ethnocentrism is the tendency to judge all other groups according to the standards, behaviors, and customs of one's own group.

Ethnocentrism is the tendency to judge other groups according to the standards, behaviors, and customs of one's own group. Given the automatic influence of one's own culture, when people compare their culture to others, they often conclude that their own is superior.[9] An even more extreme reaction is **xenophobia**, a fear of strangers and foreigners. Clearly, businesspeople who take these views are not likely to communicate successfully across cultures.

Xenophobia is a fear of strangers and foreigners.

Stereotyping is assigning generalized attributes to an individual on the basis of membership in a particular group.

Distorted views also result from **stereotyping**, which is assigning a wide range of generalized attributes to an individual on the basis of membership in a particular culture or social group. For instance, assuming that an older colleague will be out of touch with the youth market or that a younger colleague can't be an inspiring leader would be stereotyping based on age groups.

Cultural pluralism is the acceptance of multiple cultures on their own terms.

Those who want to show respect for others and to communicate effectively in business need to adopt a more positive viewpoint, in the form of **cultural pluralism**—the practice of accepting multiple cultures on their own terms. A few simple habits can help:

You can avoid ethnocentrism and stereotyping by avoiding assumptions, withholding judgment, and accepting differences.

- **Avoid assumptions.** Don't assume that others will act the same way you do, use language and symbols the same way you do, or even operate from the same values and beliefs. In other words, you need to consciously resist the automatic impulses from your own culture.
- **Avoid judgments.** When people act differently, don't conclude that they are in error or that their way is invalid or inferior. As with assumptions, avoiding judgment requires conscious effort, such as not letting someone's appearance or accent influence your perceptions.[10]
- **Acknowledge distinctions.** Don't ignore the differences between another person's culture and your own.

Unfortunately, overcoming ethnocentrism and stereotyping is not a simple task, even for people who are highly motivated to do so. Moreover, research suggests that people often have beliefs and biases they're not even aware of—and that may even conflict with the beliefs they *think* they have.[11]

3 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Explain the importance of recognizing cultural variations, and list eight key dimensions of cultural diversity.

Recognizing Variations in a Diverse World

You can begin to learn how people in other cultures want to be treated by recognizing and accommodating eight main types of cultural differences: contextual, legal and ethical, social, nonverbal, age, gender, religious, and ability (see Figure 3.1).

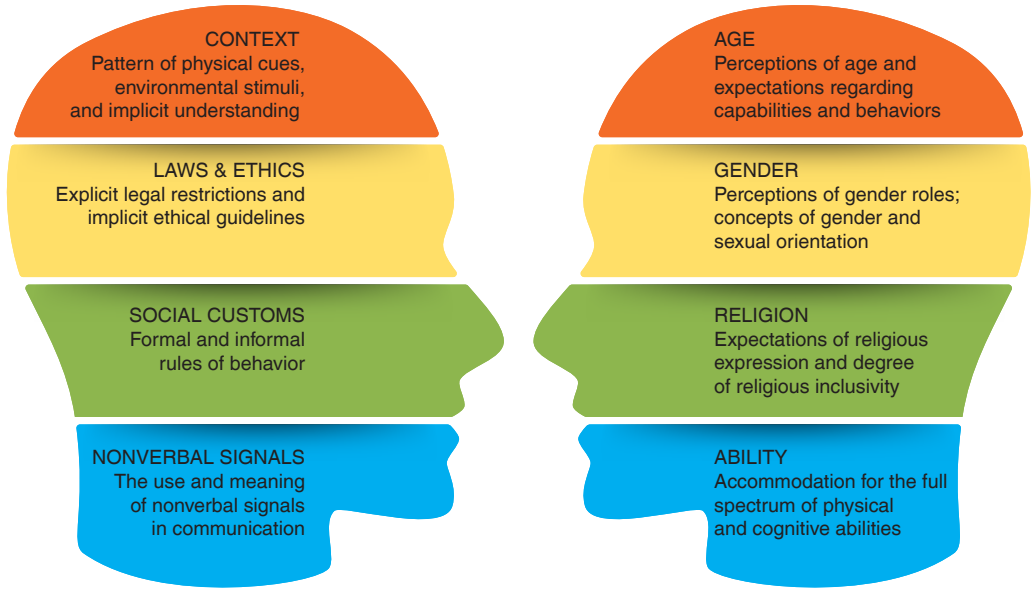


Figure 3.1 Major Dimensions of Cultural Diversity
Here are eight of the most significant variables that define any culture and can create differences between cultures.

CONTEXTUAL DIFFERENCES

Every attempt at communication occurs within a **cultural context**, which is the pattern of physical cues, environmental stimuli, and implicit understanding that convey meaning between two members of the same culture. Cultures around the world vary widely in the role that context plays in communication.

Cultural context is the pattern of physical cues, environmental stimuli, and implicit understanding that conveys meaning between members of the same culture.

In a **high-context culture**, people rely less on verbal communication and more on the context of nonverbal actions and environmental setting to convey meaning. Moreover, communication can be as much about building relationships as it can be about exchanging information. Countries often identified as having high-context cultures include China, Japan, and many Arab nations.[12]

A *high-context culture* relies heavily on nonverbal actions and environmental setting to convey meaning.

In a **low-context culture** such as those in United States, Germany, and Switzerland, people rely more on verbal communication and less on circumstances and cues to convey meaning. In such cultures, rules and expectations are usually spelled out through explicit statements. And in contrast to high-context cultures, in these cultures communication tends to emphasize exchanging information over building relationships.[13]

A *low-context culture* relies more on explicit verbal communication.

Contextual differences are apparent in the way businesspeople approach situations such as decision-making, problem solving, negotiating, interacting among levels in the organizational hierarchy, and socializing outside the workplace.[14] For instance, in low-context cultures, businesspeople tend to focus on the results of the decisions they face, a reflection of the cultural emphasis on logic and progress (for example, "Will this be good for our company? For my career?"). In comparison, high-context cultures emphasize the means or the method by which a decision will be made. Building or protecting relationships can be as important as the facts and information used in making the decisions.[15] Consequently, negotiators working on business deals in such cultures may spend most of their time together building relationships rather than hammering out contractual details.

Contextual differences influence the way businesspeople approach situations such as decision-making, problem solving, and negotiating.

The distinctions between high and low context are generalizations, of course, but they are important to keep in mind as guidelines. Communication tactics that work well in a high-context culture may backfire in a low-context culture, and vice versa.

LEGAL AND ETHICAL DIFFERENCES

Cultural context influences legal and ethical behavior, which in turn can affect communication. For example, the meaning of business contracts can vary from culture to culture. Whereas a manager from a U.S. company would tend to view a signed contract as the

Cultural context influences legal and ethical behavior, which in turn can affect communication.

end of the negotiating process, with all the details resolved, his or her counterpart in many Asian cultures might view the contract as more fluid, and continued renegotiation is common.[16]

As you conduct business around the world, you'll find that both legal systems and ethical standards differ from culture to culture. An enduring dilemma for many companies, for example, is the question of making payments to government officials to secure contracts in some countries. While the practice is so common in some locations that it's considered a standard way of doing business, paying bribes is generally illegal for U.S. companies under the Foreign Corrupt Practices Act.[17]

SOCIAL NORMS AND CUSTOMS

The nature of social behavior varies among cultures, sometimes dramatically. Some behavioral rules are formal and specifically articulated (table manners are a good example), whereas others are informal and learned over time (such as the comfortable distance to stand from a colleague during a discussion). The combination of formal and informal rules influences the overall behavior of most people in a society most of the time. Social norms can vary from culture to culture in the following areas:

- **Attitudes toward work and success.** In the United States, for instance, a widespread view is that material comfort earned by individual effort is a sign of superiority and that people who work hard are better than those who don't.

Respect and rank are reflected differently from culture to culture in the way people are addressed and in their working environment.

- **Roles and status.** Culture influences the roles people play, including who communicates with whom, what they communicate, and in what way. Countries and cultures vary widely regarding social status, both in the perceptions of different social classes and the respect one is expected to show to those of a different class. Attitudes toward the role of women in business also vary considerably from country to country.[18]

The rules of polite behavior vary from country to country.

- **Use of manners.** What is polite in one culture may be considered rude in another. For instance, asking a colleague "How was your weekend?" is a common way of making small talk in the United States, but the question sounds intrusive to people in cultures in which business and private lives are seen as separate spheres.

Attitudes toward time, such as strict adherence to meeting schedules, can vary throughout the world.

- **Concepts of time.** People in low-context cultures see time as a way to plan the business day efficiently, often focusing on only one task during each scheduled period and viewing time as a limited resource. However, people from high-context cultures often see time as more flexible. Meeting a deadline is less important than building a business relationship.[19]
- **Future orientation.** Successful companies tend to have a strong *future orientation*, planning for and investing in the future, but national cultures around the world vary widely in this viewpoint. Some societies encourage a long-term outlook that emphasizes planning and investing—making sacrifices in the short term for the promise of better outcomes in the future. Others are oriented more toward the present, even to the point of viewing the future as hopelessly remote and not worth planning for.[20]

Cultures around the world exhibit varying degrees of openness toward both outsiders and people whose personal identities don't align with prevailing social norms.

- **Openness and inclusiveness.** At the national level as well as within smaller groups, cultures vary on how open they are to accepting people from other cultures and people who don't appear to fit the prevailing norms within the culture. An unwillingness to accommodate others can range from outright exclusion to subtle pressures to conform to majority expectations.

These social customs affect how people behave in the workplace, and differences can create communication problems. For instance, the French cosmetics company L'Oréal trains its global workforce in a standardized approach to conflict management that encourages employees to express disagreement and share competing ideas. In the beginning, this style felt unnatural for its Chinese employees, whose culture discouraged open debate, but they grew to appreciate the advantages of the approach.[21]

Understanding the nuances of social customs takes time and effort, but most businesspeople are happy to explain the habits and expectations of their culture. Plus, they will view your curiosity as a sign of respect.

NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

The meaning of nonverbal signals can vary widely from culture to culture, so you can't rely on assumptions.

As Chapter 2 notes, nonverbal communication can be a helpful guide to determining the meaning of a message—but this holds true only if the sender and receiver assign the same meaning to nonverbal signals. For instance, the simplest hand gestures have different meanings in different cultures. Gestures you may have been using in the United States all your life, such as giving someone a thumbs up to indicate agreement or approval, can have different and sometimes extremely rude meanings in other cultures.[22] If you will be visiting another country or hosting a visitor to your country, do some quick research about acceptable gestures to avoid embarrassing mistakes.

When you have the opportunity to interact with people in another culture, the best advice is to study the culture in advance and then observe the way people behave in the following areas:

Cultural norms influence the use of many nonverbal signals and behaviors:
- How people greet one another
- Respect for personal space
- Habits of touching
- Facial expressions
- Eye contact
- Posture
- Degree of formality

- **Greetings.** Do people shake hands, bow, or kiss lightly (on one side of the face or both)? Do people shake hands only when first introduced or every time they say hello or goodbye?
- **Personal space.** When people are conversing, do they stand closer together or farther away than you are accustomed to?
- **Touching.** Do people touch each other on the arm to emphasize a point or slap each other on the back to show congratulations? Or do they refrain from touching altogether? Some cultures are much more touch-oriented than others but, as always, you must be careful to avoid forms of touch that can be misinterpreted as domineering or sexual in nature.
- **Facial expressions.** Do people smile at strangers, for example? This is common behavior in the United States, but it is not universal.
- **Eye contact.** Do people make frequent eye contact or avoid it? Frequent eye contact is often taken as a sign of honesty and openness in the United States, but in other cultures it can be a sign of aggressiveness or disrespect.
- **Posture.** Do people slouch and relax in the office and in public, or do they sit up and stand up straight?
- **Formality.** In general, does the culture seem more or less formal than yours?

Following the lead of people who grew up in the culture is a great way to learn and a good way to show respect as well.

AGE DIFFERENCES

Every generation has been shaped by dramatically different world events, social trends, and technological advances.

The multiple generations within a culture present another dimension of diversity. Today's workplaces can have three, four, or even five generations working side by side. Each has been shaped by dramatically different world events, social trends, and technological advances, so it is not surprising that they often have different values, expectations, and communication habits. Throw in the human tendencies to resist change and to assume that whatever way one is doing something must be the best way to do it, and you have a recipe for conflict. Moreover, generations in a workplace sometimes feel they are competing for jobs, resources, influence, and control. The result can be tension, mistrust, and communication breakdowns.

Lumping people into generations is an imprecise science at best, but it helps to know the labels commonly applied to various age groups. Be aware, however, that there are no official labels or year ranges for these generations. Over time, these have come into general use by population researchers and the news media. The only one of these group labels used by the U.S. Census Bureau, for instance, is baby boomers. Here are the labels and birth years used by the Pew Research Center, a leading independent research organization. (Pew is waiting for a consensus to emerge regarding a label for the post-millennial generation.)[23]

- **The Silent Generation (born 1928–1945).** People in this group are beyond what was once considered the traditional retirement age of 65, but a small number want or need to continue working.
- **Baby Boomers (1946–1964).** This generation, which got its name from the population boom in the years following World War II, is gradually moving into

retirement. However, many baby boomers will continue to work beyond age 65—and hold on to many top management positions that younger employees would like to move into.

- **Generation X (1965–1980).** This group, the second-largest generation in the workforce, sometimes feels caught between the large mass of older baby boomers and the younger millennial generation. As Generation X takes over corporate leadership, it is managing in a vastly different business landscape—one in which virtual organizations and networks of independent contractors replace some of the hierarchy inherited from the baby boomers.
- **Millennials (1981–1996).** This largest generation in the workforce, sometimes referred to as Generation Y, is noted for its entrepreneurial instincts and desire for a more open and sociable workplace than many of their older peers.
- **"Post-Millennials" (1997–).** This group, sometimes known as Generation Z, is just beginning to move into the workforce.

These brief summaries can hardly do justice to entire generations of workers, but they give you some idea of the different generational perspectives and the potential for communication problems. As with all cultural conflicts, successful communication starts with recognizing and understanding both differences and similarities. Beneath the superficial differences in technology usage and other factors, various generations are often more alike than they are different.

Commonly defined generations such as millennials or baby boomers represent tens of millions of people in the United States alone, so don't interpret broad statements about any generation as universal truths.

When you hear statements about the beliefs and behaviors of a particular generation, always bear in mind that these are broad generalities. For example, more than 70 million people in the United States alone fall in the millennial designation, and any group that large is bound to have a wide range of beliefs and behaviors. In addition, the age ranges are not hard-and-fast boundaries in terms of human behavior. The first "Gen Xer" (born on January 1, 1965) doesn't automatically think and behave differently than the last baby boomer (born one day earlier on December 31, 1964).

In the workplace and in your communication activities, approach age as you would any other dimension of diversity: Resist the urge to make assumptions about an individual from another age group, and don't assume that your own group's approach is automatically superior.

GENDER DIFFERENCES

The perception of men and women in business varies from culture to culture.

Gender influences workplace communication in several important ways. First, the perception of men and women in business varies from culture to culture, and gender bias can range from overt discrimination to subtle and even unconscious beliefs.

Gender imbalances tend to get pronounced the further up the corporate ladder you look.

Second, although the ratio of men to women in entry-level professional positions is roughly equal, the percentage of management roles held by men increases steadily the further up the corporate ladder one looks. This imbalance can significantly affect communication in such areas as mentoring, which is a vital development opportunity for lower and middle managers who want to move into senior positions.

Broadly speaking, men tend to emphasize content in their messages, whereas women tend to emphasize relationship maintenance.

Third, evidence suggests that men and women tend to have somewhat different communication styles. Broadly speaking, men emphasize content and outcomes in their communication efforts, whereas women place a higher premium on relationship maintenance.[24] As one example, men are more likely than women to try to negotiate a pay raise. Moreover, according to research by Linda Babcock of Carnegie Mellon University, both men and women tend to accept this disparity, viewing assertiveness as a positive quality in men but a negative quality in women. Changing these perceptions could go a long way toward improving communication and equity in the workplace.[25]

Many people do not fit or wish to be fit into a simplistic heterosexual, male/female categorization scheme.

Fourth, outdated concepts of gender and sexual orientation continue to be a source of confusion, controversy, and discrimination. Many people do not fit or wish to be fit into a simplistic heterosexual, male/female categorization scheme, but discriminatory company policies and the behaviors and attitudes of supervisors and coworkers can deprive these individuals of a fair and satisfying work experience. In response, many companies have taken steps to ensure equal opportunities and fair treatment for lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and questioning (LGBTQ) job applicants and employees.

Companies can also take steps to make sure their nondiscrimination policies protect employees' right to gender expression based on personal gender identity.[26] Communication plays a critical role in all these efforts, from listening to the needs of diverse employee groups to providing clear policies and educating employees on important issues.

RELIGIOUS DIFFERENCES

As one of the most personal and influential aspects of life, religion brings potential for controversy and conflict in the workplace setting. Many employees believe they should be able to follow and express the tenets of their faith in the workplace. In the United States, a variety of laws prohibit discrimination and harassment based on religion and require employers to make reasonable accommodations for religious beliefs and practices.[27]

U.S. law requires employers to accommodate employees' religious beliefs to a reasonable degree.

However, efforts to accommodate religions can sometimes create conflict in the workplace and with the demands of operating the business. The situation is complex, with no simple answers that apply to every situation. As more companies work to establish inclusive workplaces, you can expect to see this issue being discussed more often in the coming years.

ABILITY DIFFERENCES

Colleagues and customers with disabilities that affect communication represent an important aspect of the diversity picture. For example, people whose hearing, vision, cognitive ability, or physical ability to operate digital devices or machinery is impaired can be at a significant disadvantage in today's workplace. A growing number of companies now recognize the concept of *neurodiversity*, which refers to atypical thought and behavior patterns such as autism and social anxiety disorders, and the challenges that neurodiverse employees face.[28] As with other elements of diversity, success starts with respect for individuals and sensitivity to differences.

Assistive technologies help employers create more inclusive workplaces and benefit from the contribution of people with physical or cognitive impairments.

Employers can invest in a variety of *assistive technologies* that help people with disabilities perform activities that might otherwise be difficult or impossible. These technologies include devices and systems that help workers communicate, interact with computers and other equipment, and enjoy greater mobility in the workplace. Artificial intelligence and robotics are enabling an exciting new generation of assistive technologies. If you are interested in learning more about these tools or perhaps working for one of the companies that make them, search online for "assistive technologies."

Making information more accessible for all stakeholders is another key step that all companies can take. For example, people with vision impairments can use *screen readers* that convert on-screen text to audio. However, for these systems to work, the source material needs to be formatted in specific ways. Microsoft Word and Adobe Acrobat, two of the most commonly used document preparation tools in business, both offer advice on how to format documents for screen readers.

Adapting to Other Business Cultures

4 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
List four general guidelines for adapting to any business culture.

Whether you're trying to work productively with members of another generation in your own office or with a business partner on the other side of the world, adapting your approach is essential to successful communication. This section offers general advice on adapting to any business culture and specific advice for professionals from other cultures on adapting to U.S. business culture.

GUIDELINES FOR ADAPTING TO ANY BUSINESS CULTURE

You'll find a variety of tips in "Improving Intercultural Communication Skills," starting on page 123, but here are four general guidelines that can help all business communicators improve their cultural competency:

An important step in understanding and adapting to other cultures is to recognize the influences that your own culture has on your communication habits.

- **Become aware of your own biases.** Successful intercultural communication requires more than just an understanding of the other party's culture; you need to understand your own culture and the way it shapes your communication habits.[29] For instance, recognizing that you value independence and individual accomplishment will help you communicate more successfully in a culture that values consensus and group harmony.

Ignore the Golden Rule; treat people the way *they* want to be treated, not the way *you* want to be treated.

- **Be careful about applying the "Golden Rule."** You probably heard this growing up: "Treat people the way you want to be treated." The problem with the Golden Rule is that other people don't always want to be treated the same way you want to be treated, particularly across cultural boundaries. A better approach: Treat people the way *they* want to be treated.
- **Be accommodating and respectful, even if you don't understand or agree.** This can be an easy point to overlook in the rush of a business day, but cultural differences are in fact *different*. Being aware of differences is an essential first step, but it doesn't go far enough. Changing one's attitudes and behaviors to accommodate differences takes sustained effort and commitment.

Patience and a sense of humor can get you through most awkward moments in cross-cultural interaction.

- **Be patient and maintain a sense of humor.** Even the most committed and attuned business professionals can make mistakes in intercultural communication, so it is vital for all parties to be patient with one another. A sense of humor is a helpful asset as well, allowing people to move past awkward and embarrassing moments. When you make a mistake, simply apologize and, if appropriate, ask the other person to explain the accepted way; then move on.

GUIDELINES FOR ADAPTING TO U.S. BUSINESS CULTURE

If you are a recent immigrant to the United States or grew up in a culture outside the U.S. mainstream, you can apply all the concepts and skills in this chapter to adapt to U.S. business culture. Here are some key points to remember as you become accustomed to business communication in this country:

The values espoused by U.S. culture include individualism, equality, and privacy.

- **Individualism.** In contrast to cultures that value group harmony and group success, U.S. culture generally expects individuals to succeed by their own efforts, and it rewards individual success.[30] These reward mechanisms are not always fair, by any means, but individual reward remains an ideal. This emphasis on individual responsibility and reward can sometimes clash with the team orientation that many companies have.
- **Equality.** Although the country's historical record on equality has not always been positive and inequalities still exist, equality is considered a core American value. This principle applies to race, gender, social background, and even age. Americans generally believe that every person should be given the opportunity to pursue whatever dreams and goals he or she has in life.
- **Privacy and personal space.** Although this appears to be changing somewhat with the popularity of social networking and other personal media, people in the United States are accustomed to a fair amount of privacy. This applies to physical space as well; U.S. businesspeople tend to stand farther apart when talking than people in some other cultures do, for example.[31]
- **Time and schedules.** U.S. businesses value punctuality and the efficient use of time. For instance, meetings are typically expected to start and end at designated times.
- **Religion.** The United States does not have an official state religion. Many religions are practiced throughout the country, and people are expected to respect each other's beliefs. Again, this respect and accommodation is more an ideal than universal practice, but it is an ideal nonetheless.
- **Communication style.** Communication tends to be direct and focused more on content and transactions than on relationships or group harmony.

As with all observations about culture, these are generalizations, of course. Any nation of more than 300 million people will exhibit a wide variety of behaviors. However, following these guidelines will help you succeed in most business communication situations.

Improving Intercultural Communication Skills

5 LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Identify six steps you can take to improve your intercultural communication skills.

Communicating successfully across cultures requires a variety of skills (see Figure 3.2). You can improve your intercultural skills throughout your career by studying other cultures and languages, respecting preferences for communication styles, writing clearly, speaking and listening carefully, knowing when to use interpreters and translators, and helping others adapt to your culture.

STUDYING OTHER CULTURES

Successful intercultural communication can require the modification of personal communication habits.

Effectively adapting your communication efforts to another culture requires not only knowledge about the culture but also the ability and motivation to change your personal habits as needed.[32] Fortunately, you don't need to learn about the whole world all at once. Many companies appoint specialists for countries or regions, giving employees a chance to focus on just one culture at a time. And if your employer conducts business internationally, it may offer training and support for employees who need to learn more about specific cultures.

Even a small amount of research and practice will help you get through many business situations. In addition, most people respond positively to honest effort and good intentions, and many business associates will help you along if you show an interest in learning more about their cultures. Don't be afraid to ask questions. People will respect

Making an effort to learn about another person's culture is a sign of respect.

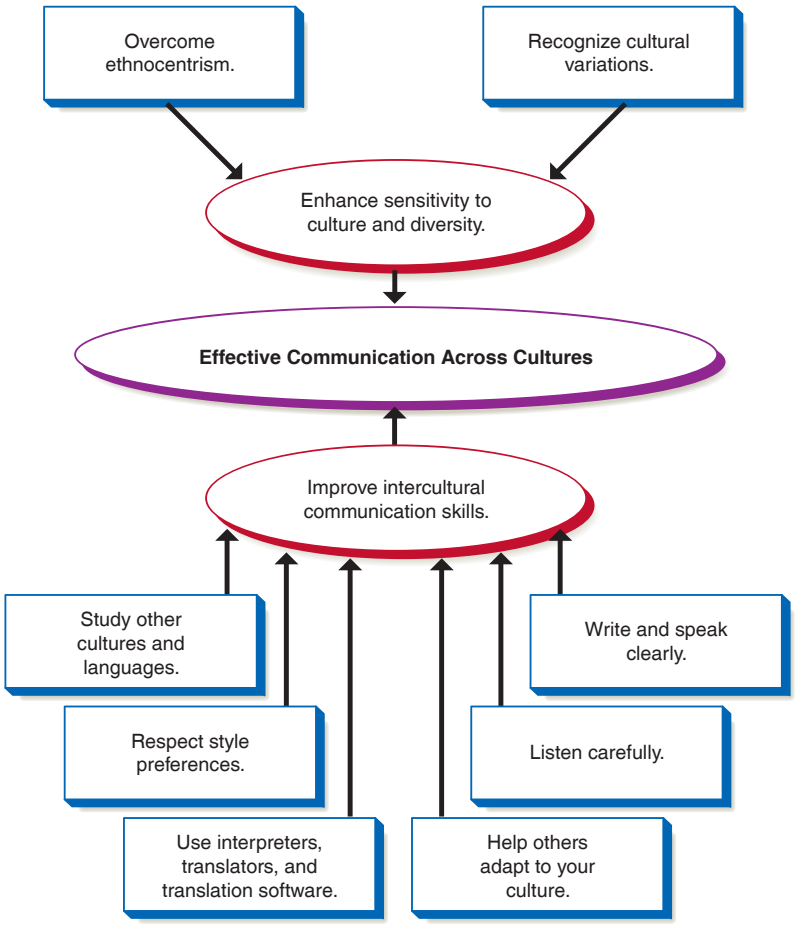


Figure 3.2 Components of Successful Intercultural Communication
Communicating in a diverse business environment is not always an easy task, but you can continue to improve your sensitivity and build your skills as you progress in your career.

your concern and curiosity. You will gradually accumulate considerable knowledge, which will help you feel comfortable and be effective in a wide range of business situations.

Numerous websites and books offer advice on traveling to other countries and working in specific cultures. Also try to sample newspapers, magazines, and even the music and movies of another country. For instance, a movie can demonstrate nonverbal customs even if you don't grasp the language. However, be careful not to rely solely on entertainment products. If people in other countries based their opinions of U.S. culture solely on the silly comedies and violent action movies the United States exports around the globe, what sort of impression do you imagine they would get?

For some of the key issues to research before doing business in another country, refer to Table 3.1.

TABLE 3.1 Doing Business in Other Cultures

Action	Details to Consider
Understand social customs	● How do people react to strangers? Are they friendly? Hostile? Reserved? ● How do people greet each other? Should you bow? Nod? Shake hands? ● How do people express appreciation for an invitation to lunch, dinner, or someone's home? Should you bring a gift? Send flowers? Write a thank-you note? ● Are any phrases, facial expressions, or hand gestures considered rude? ● How do you attract the attention of a waiter? Do you tip the waiter? ● When is it rude to refuse an invitation? How do you refuse politely? ● What topics may or may not be discussed in a social setting? In a business setting? ● How do social customs dictate interaction between men and women? Between younger people and older people?
Learn about clothing and food preferences	● What occasions require special attire? ● What colors are associated with mourning? Love? Joy? ● Are some types of clothing considered taboo for one gender or the other? ● How many times a day do people eat? ● How are hands or utensils used when eating? ● Where is the seat of honor at a table?
Assess political patterns	● How stable is the political situation? ● Does the political situation affect businesses in and out of the country? ● Is it appropriate to talk politics in social or business situations?
Understand religious and social beliefs	● To which religious groups do people belong? ● Which places, objects, actions, and events are sacred? ● Do religious beliefs affect communication between men and women or between any other groups? ● Is there a tolerance for minority religions? ● How do religious holidays affect business and government activities? ● Does religion require or prohibit eating specific foods? Eating at specific times?
Learn about economic and business institutions	● Is the society homogeneous or heterogeneous? ● What languages are spoken? ● What are the primary resources and principal products? ● Are businesses generally large? Family controlled? Government controlled? ● What are the generally accepted working hours? ● How do people view scheduled appointments? ● Are people expected to socialize before conducting business?
Appraise the nature of ethics, values, and laws	● Is money or a gift expected in exchange for arranging business transactions? ● Do people value competitiveness or cooperation? ● What are the attitudes toward work? Toward money? ● Is politeness more important than factual honesty?

STUDYING OTHER LANGUAGES

As commerce continues to become more globalized and many countries become more linguistically diverse, the demand for multilingual communicators continues to grow as well. The ability to communicate in more than one language can make you a more competitive job candidate and can open up a wider variety of career opportunities.

Even if your colleagues or customers in another country speak your language, it's worth the time and energy to learn common phrases in theirs. Doing so helps you get through everyday business and social situations and demonstrates your commitment to the business relationship. After all, the other person probably spent years learning your language.

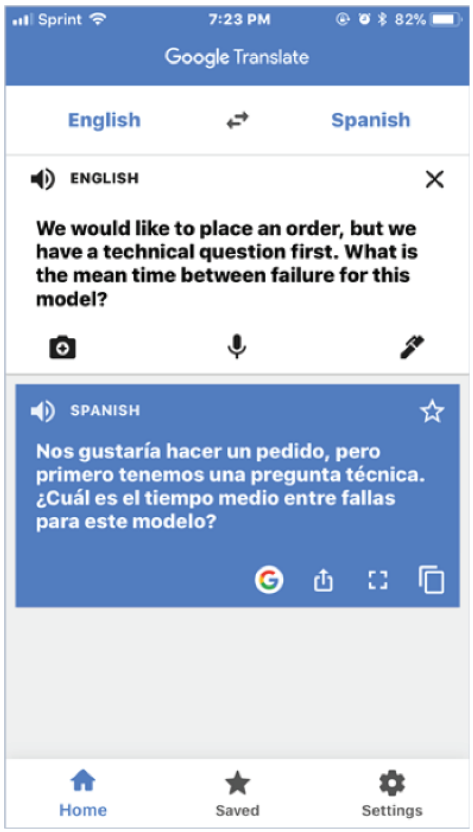
Even if your colleagues or customers in another country speak your language, make the effort to learn some common phrases in theirs.

Mobile devices can be a huge help in learning another language and in communicating with someone in another language. A wide variety of apps and websites are available that help with essential words and phrases, grammar, pronunciation, text translation, and even real-time audio translation (see Figure 3.3).

MOBILE APP

Memrise can help you learn new languages with the help of a worldwide community of fellow learners.

Finally, don't assume that people from two countries who speak the same language speak it the same way. The French spoken in Québec and other parts of Canada is often noticeably different from the French spoken in France. Similarly, it's often said that the United States and the United Kingdom are two countries divided by a common language. For instance, *period* (punctuation), *elevator*, and *gasoline* in the United States are *full stop*, *lift*, and *petrol* in the United Kingdom.



Courtesy of Android.

Figure 3.3 Mobile Language Tools
Translation apps are handy tools for working in multilingual business settings. Even if you don't speak a word of a particular language, you can get fast translations of essential phrases.

RESPECTING PREFERENCES FOR COMMUNICATION STYLE

Communication in many other cultures is more formal and less direct than it is in the United States, and politeness is valued highly.

Communication style—including the level of directness, the degree of formality, media preferences, and other factors—varies widely from culture to culture (see Figures 3.4a through 3.4d). Generally speaking, communication in many other cultures is more formal and less direct than it is in the United States, and politeness is valued highly.[33] To get up-to-date advice on communication with people in another country, search online for the specific country you are interest in (for example, "French business correspondence," "German business correspondence").

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Zhejang Shan Tou Manufacturing Company, Ltd.
Guoliwei Industry Park
Libang Road, Longgang District
Shenzhen, Guangdong, China

Dear Mr. Li,

My company, Updraft RC, has designed a cool new line of radio-control toys that use smartphones as the controller. We are looking for a manufacturing partner, and your firm is one of the candidates we're having a look at.

Before we discuss technical details, I must say I have two sets of concerns about working with a foreign manufacturer. The first involves all the usual—transportation costs, delays, quality control, and risk of intellectual property theft. I'll need some assurances on how you address these issues to make sure they don't become problems in our relationship.

Second, companies here in the States that use foreign manufacturers often have to deal with heavy news coverage and activist publicity on such matters as workplace safety, worker rights, and environmentally sensitive manufacturing. Even though the U.S. company doesn't directly control what happens in the overseas contract manufacturer, the U.S. company takes the heat when the media uncovers abuse, neglect, pollution, etc. I know that Nike and other U.S. companies have spent millions and worked for years to promote positive conditions in overseas factories, but even these major corporations haven't been able to completely avoid problems and bad press. How can I be sure that a small company such as ours will? I do not want our product launch to get caught up in some scandal over "sweatshops."

I look forward to seeing your comprehensive response as soon as possible.

All the best,

Henry Gatlin

Henry Gatlin
Founder, CEO
Updraft RC

5 August 2021

- Language such as *cool* and *having a look at* is too informal for external business communication, particularly for international correspondence.
- The tone of this paragraph is too demanding.
- *Here in the States* is too informal, and referring to the reader as *foreign* is potentially insulting.
- Inflammatory language such as *bad press, scandal,* and *sweatshops* will put the reader on the defensive and discourage a positive response.
- The request for a response sounds too demanding, and it lacks a specific deadline.
- The closing is too informal.

Figure 3.4a Intercultural Business Letter: Ineffective Original Draft
This letter (from a Kentucky company that designs radio-controlled airplanes) exhibits a number of problems that would create difficulties for its intended reader (the manager of a contract manufacturing company in China). Follow the changes in Figures 3.4b, 3.4c, and 3.4d to see how the letter was adapted and then translated for its target audience.

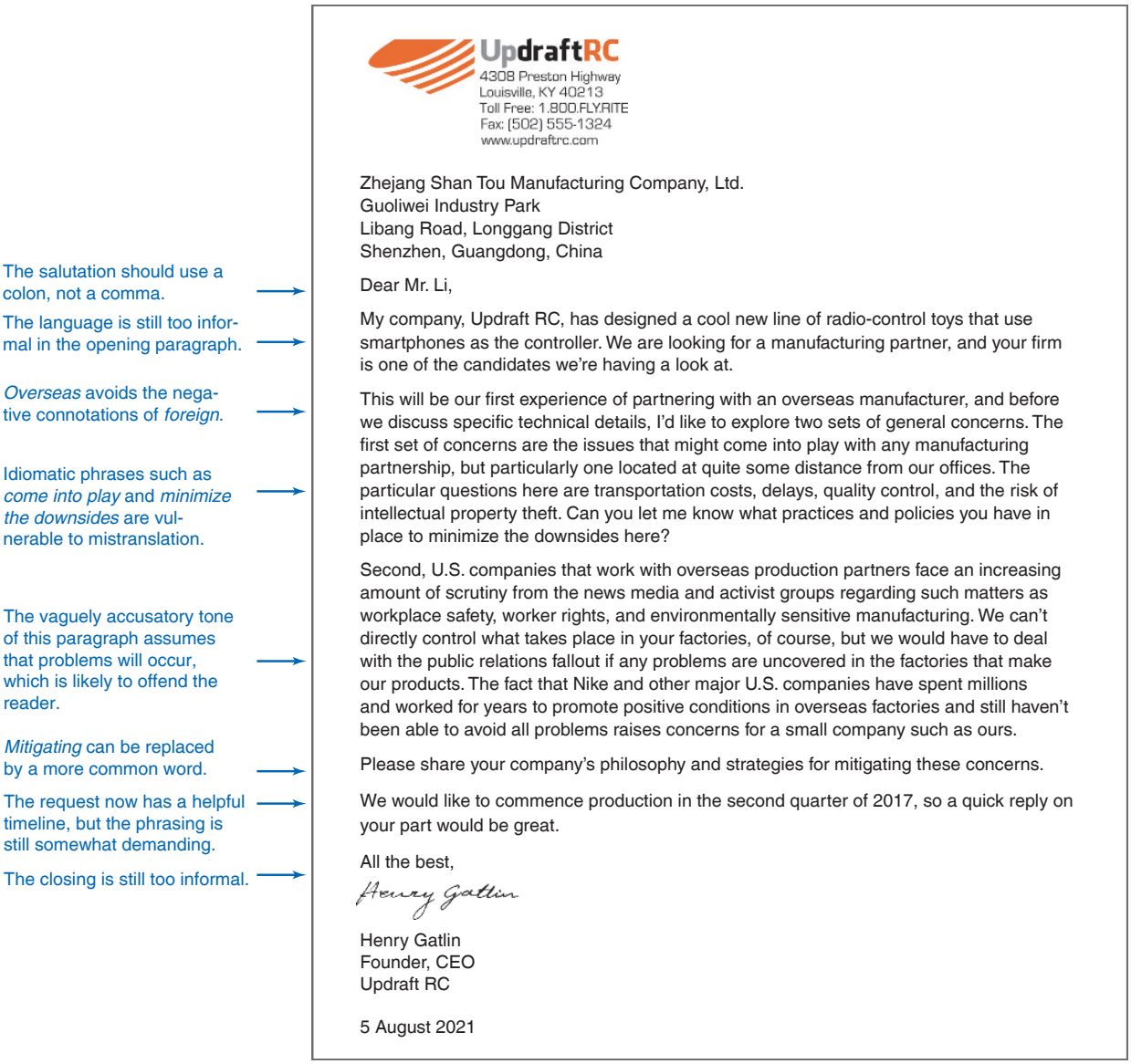


Figure 3.4b Intercultural Business Letter: First Revision
This version eliminates most of the problems with overly informal phrases and potentially offensive language. With these revisions, it would function well as a message between native speakers of English, but it still has some wording and formatting issues that could create difficulties for a Chinese reader. Compare with Figure 3.4c.

WRITING CLEARLY

Writing clearly is always important, of course, but it is essential when you are writing to people whose first language differs from yours. Follow these recommendations to make sure your message can be understood:

Clarity and simplicity are essential when writing to or speaking with people who don't share your native language.

- **Chose words carefully.** Look for short, precise words that say exactly what you mean.
- **Avoid words with multiple meanings.** As much as possible, choose words that have only one obvious meaning in the context in which you're using them. For example, *right* has more than 30 distinct meanings and can function as a noun, an adjective, a verb, and an adverb.[34] Whenever appropriate, use a synonym that conveys the specific meaning you intend, such as *correct*, *appropriate*, *desirable*, *moral*, *authentic*, or *privilege*.[35]



UpdraftRC
4308 Preston Highway
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www.updraftrc.com

Dear Mr. Li:

With the widespread adoption of mobile phones, more and more accessories and associated products are being developed to meet new market demands. My company, Updraft RC, has designed a new line of radio-controlled toys that use smartphones as the controller. Our market tests show strong potential for demand among younger consumers, who are often eager to try new products. We are now looking for a manufacturing partner, and we are very willing to collaborate with you.

This will be our first experience of partnering with an overseas manufacturer, and before we discuss specific technical details, I would like you to know two of our general concerns. The first concern involves all the general challenges of a long-distance manufacturing partnership, including transportation costs, shipping delays, quality control, and the risk of intellectual property theft.

Second, U.S. companies that work with overseas production partners face an increasing amount of scrutiny from the news media and activist groups regarding such matters as workplace safety, worker rights, and environmentally sensitive manufacturing. Nike and other major U.S. companies have spent millions of dollars and worked for years to improve conditions in overseas factories, but even they have not been able to avoid all problems. As a small company with no ability to monitor factories, we are worried about any manufacturing-related problems that could affect our public image.

Please share your company's philosophy and strategies for minimizing these two concerns.

We would like to commence production in the second quarter of 2017, so we would like to hear your reply as soon as possible.

Thank you,



Henry Gatlin
Founder, CEO
Updraft RC

5 August 2021

← An inside address is typically not used in Chinese correspondence.

← The salutation uses a colon rather than a comma.

← The revised opening gives the reader some helpful context and the assurance that this is a meaningful business opportunity.

← The phrase "we are very willing to collaborate with you" shows respect for the reader and suggests the interest in forming a partnership.

← This paragraph has been shortened to eliminate the redundant request for information.

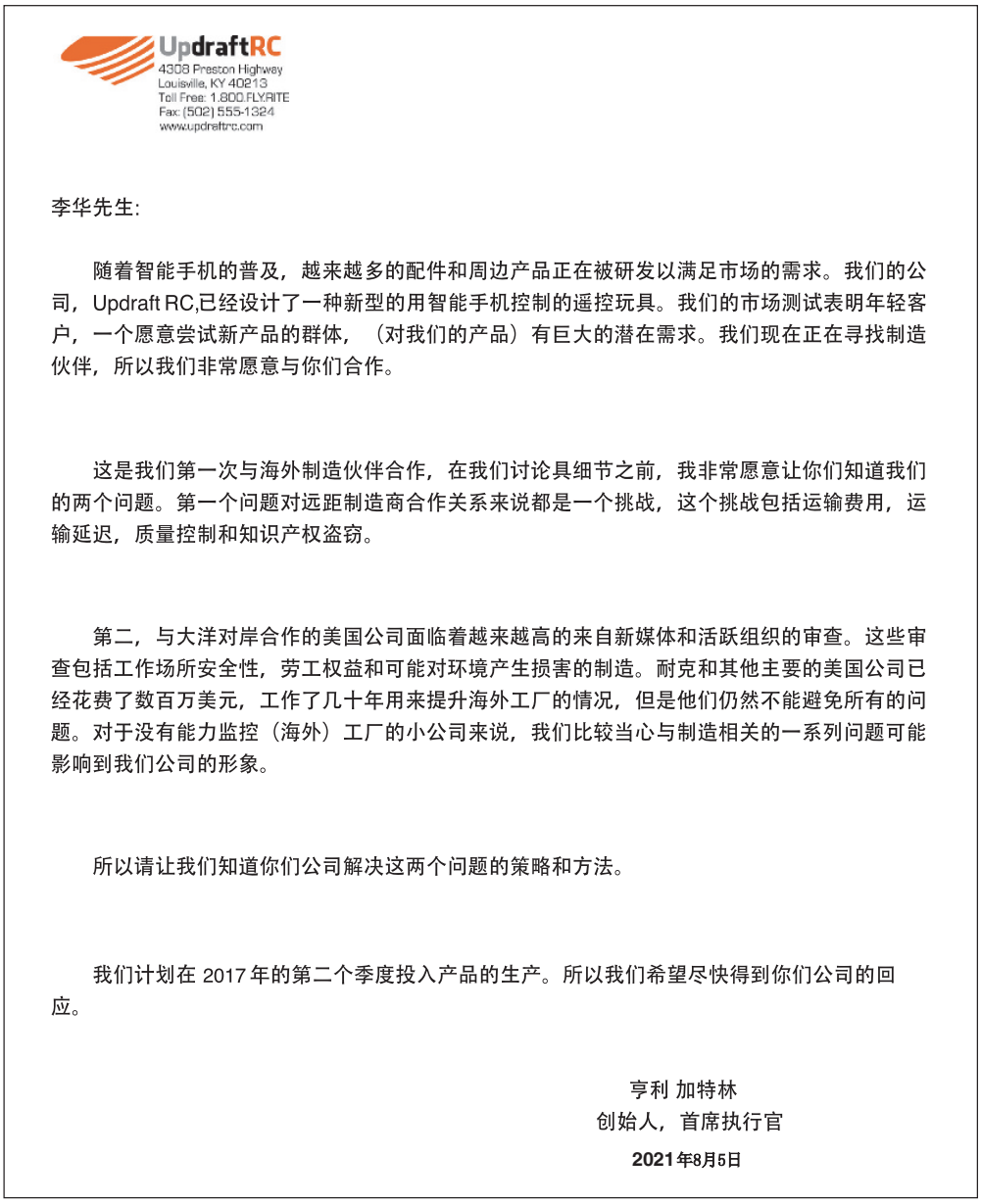
← This revised paragraph still conveys the seriousness of the writer's concerns without offending the reader.

← *Minimizing* is easier for a nonnative speaker to understand than *mitigating*.

← "Thank you" is a simple and adequately formal closing.

Figure 3.4c **Intercultural Business Letter: Final Revision**
Here is the final English version, revised to ensure more successful translation into Chinese and to conform to standard practices in Chinese business communication (including removing the inside address).

- **Write short, clear sentences.** Restrict each sentence to a single idea so that anyone translating it can focus on one idea at a time.
- **Keep paragraphs short.** Similarly, break information into smaller chunks that are easier for readers to process.
- **Use transitions generously.** Help readers follow your train of thought by using transitional words and phrases. For example, tie related points together with expressions such as *in addition* and *first*, *second*, and *third*.
- **Address international correspondence properly.** Refer to Appendix A for more information.
- **Cite numbers and dates in local formats.** Various countries use different formats for numbers and dates, so it's important to know what your readers expect. In the United States, for example, 12-05-22 refers to December 5 in the year 2022, but in many other countries, it means May 12. Similarly, in the United States and Great Britain, 1.000 means one with three decimal places, but it means one thousand in many European countries.



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李华先生:

随着智能手机的普及，越来越多的配件和周边产品正在被研发以满足市场的需求。我们的公司，Updraft RC,已经设计了一种新型的用智能手机控制的遥控玩具。我们的市场测试表明年轻客户，一个愿意尝试新产品的群体，（对我们的产品）有巨大的潜在需求。我们现在正在寻找制造伙伴，所以我们非常愿意与你们合作。

这是我们第一次与海外制造伙伴合作，在我们讨论具细节之前，我非常愿意让你们知道我们的两个问题。第一个问题对远距制造商合作关系来说都是一个挑战，这个挑战包括运输费用，运输延迟，质量控制和知识产权盗窃。

第二，与大洋对岸合作的美国公司面临着越来越高的来自新媒体和活跃组织的审查。这些审查包括工作场所安全性，劳工权益和可能对环境产生损害的制造。耐克和其他主要的美国公司已经花费了数百万美元，工作了几十年用来提升海外工厂的情况，但是他们仍然不能避免所有的问题。对于没有能力监控（海外）工厂的小公司来说，我们比较当心与制造相关的一系列问题可能影响到我们公司的形象。

所以请让我们知道你们公司解决这两个问题的策略和方法。

我们计划在 2017 年的第二个季度投入产品的生产。所以我们希望尽快得到你们公司的回应。

亨利 加特林
创始人，首席执行官
2021年8月5日

Figure 3.4d Intercultural Business Letter: Translated Version
Here is the translated version, formatted in accordance with Chinese business communication practices.

- **Avoid slang and idiomatic phrases.** Slang and **idiomatic phrases**—sayings that mean more than the sum of their literal parts—usually don't travel well across languages. For instance, complimenting someone for a "killer idea" makes sense to many U.S. English speakers, but it would make little sense to someone who knows only the literal meaning of the word *killer*. Similarly, your audience may have no idea what you're talking about if you use "knocked one out of the park," "more bang for the buck," and other idiomatic phrases.
- **Generally, avoid humor and references to popular culture.** Jokes and references to popular entertainment often rely on culture-specific information that might be completely unknown to your audience.

When writing to someone who doesn't share your native language, avoid slang and *idiomatic phrases*—sayings that mean more than the sum of their literal parts.

Humor does not "travel well" because it usually relies on intimate knowledge of a particular culture.

Figure 3.5 on the next page shows how attention to these details can make a message much easier for readers whose native language is different from yours.

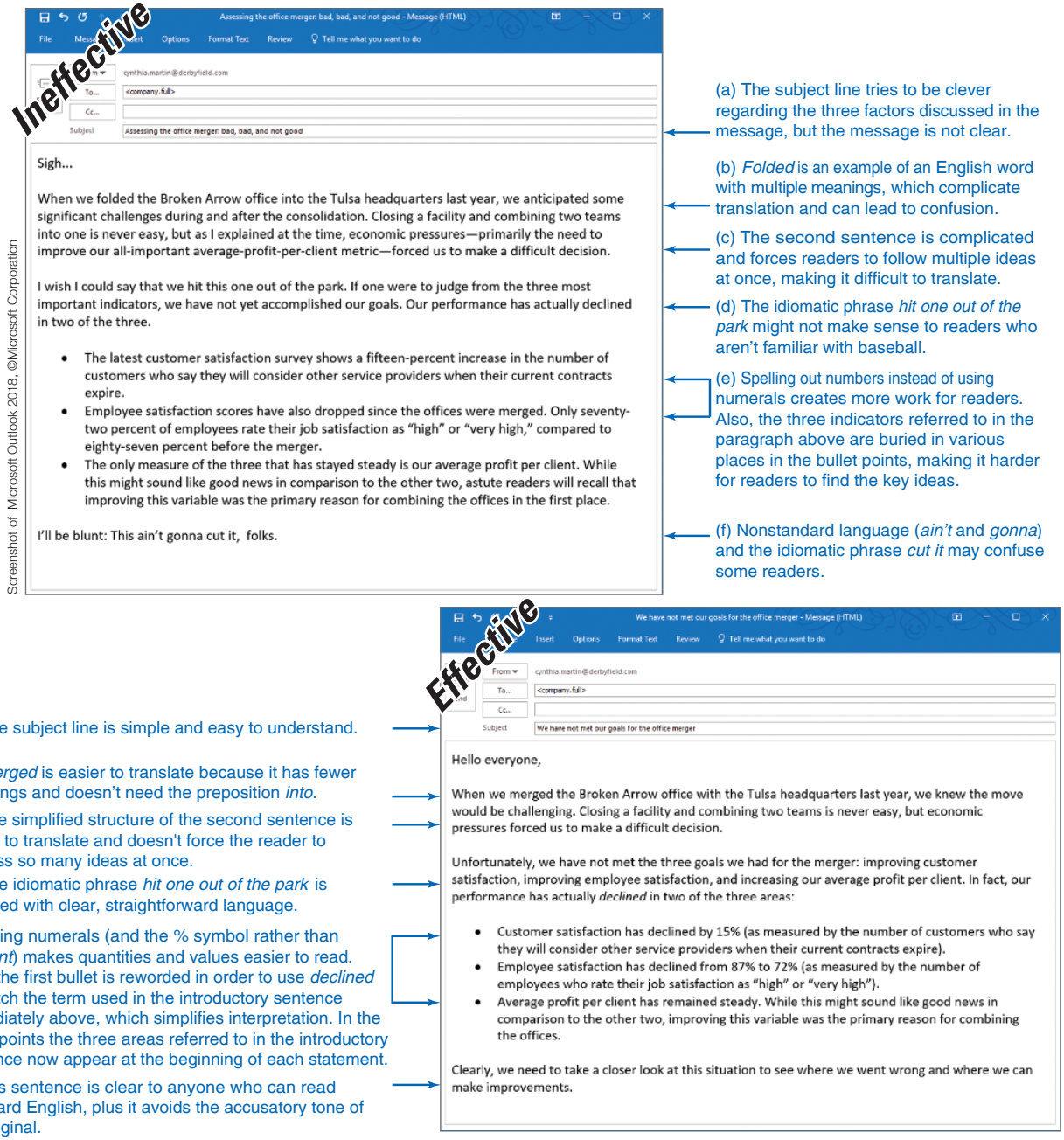


Figure 3.5 Writing for Multilingual Audiences
In today's global and diversified work environment, chances are that many of your messages will be read by people whose native language is not English. Notice how specific wording changes and modifications to sentence structure make the effective version easier for nonnative speakers to read.

SPEAKING AND LISTENING CAREFULLY

Languages vary in the significance of tone, pitch, speed, and volume, which can create challenges for people trying to interpret the explicit meaning of words themselves as well as the overall nuance of a message. The English word *progress* can be a noun or a verb, depending on which syllable you emphasize. In Chinese, the meaning of the word *ma* changes depending on the speaker's tone; it can mean *mother, hemp, horse,* or *scold*.[36]

To ensure successful conversations between parties who speak different native languages or even regional variations of the same language, speakers and listeners alike need to make accommodations.[37] Speakers should adjust the content of their messages and the style of their delivery to accommodate the needs of their listeners and the circumstances of the conversation. For example, if you are speaking in person or over a video connection, you can use hand gestures and other nonverbal signals to clarify your spoken message. However, when you don't have a visual connection, you must take extra care to convey your meaning through words and vocal characteristics alone. Conversely, listeners need to be tolerant of accents, vocabulary choices, gestures, and other factors that might distract them from hearing the meaning of a speaker's message.

When talking with people whose native language is different from yours, remember that the processing of even everyday conversations can be difficult. For instance, speakers from the United States sometimes string together multiple words into a single, mystifying pseudo-word, such as turning "Did you eat yet?" into "Jeetyet?" In spoken French, many word pairs are joined as a matter of rule, and the pronunciation can change depending on which words are next to one another. In these instances, listeners who aren't fluent in French can have a hard time telling when one word ends and the next one begins.

To be more effective in conversations with people from other language backgrounds, remember these tips: (1) Speak slowly and clearly; (2) don't rephrase until it's obviously necessary (immediately rephrasing something doubles the translation workload for the listener); (3) look for and ask for feedback to make sure your message is getting through; (4) don't talk down to the other person by overenunciating words or oversimplifying sentences to a degree that is potentially insulting; and (5) at the end of the conversation, double-check to make sure you and the listener agree on what has been said and decided.

As a listener, you'll need some practice to get a sense of vocal patterns. The key is simply to accept what you hear first, without jumping to conclusions about meaning or motivation. Let other people finish what they have to say. If you interrupt, you may miss something important. You'll also show a lack of respect. If you do not understand a comment, ask the person to repeat it. Any momentary awkwardness you might feel in asking for extra help is less important than the risk of unsuccessful communication.

To ensure successful conversations between parties who speak different native languages or even regional variations of the same language, speakers and listeners alike need to make accommodations.

To listen more effectively in intercultural situations, accept what you hear without judgment, and let people finish what they have to say.

MOBILE APP

iTranslate translates more than 100 languages and features voice input and output.

To be more effective in intercultural conversations, remember these tips:

- Speak slowly and clearly.
- Don't rephrase until it's obviously necessary.
- Look for and ask for feedback.
- Don't talk down to the other person.
- Double-check to make sure you and the other party agree.

INTELLIGENT COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGY

Real-Time Translation

Trying to converse in a language in which you are not fully fluent presents a staggering cognitive workload. As a listener, you must convert the incoming sounds to discrete words and assemble those words into coherent phrases and sentences to extract the meaning—and if the other party uses idioms or slang, the task can get exponentially harder. And unlike reading a written document, you must do all this processing almost instantaneously, without the luxury of going back over something you didn't get. As a speaker, you have to find the right words, assemble them into phrases and sentences using the language's grammar rules, and then pronounce them all correctly enough so they make sense to the other party. Honing this level of proficiency can take years of study and practice.

Machine translation has been one of the long-standing goals of artificial intelligence, offering hope for real-time communication between people who don't have a common language. Systems such as Skype Translator and Google Translate are getting remarkably adept. Google's Pixel Buds ear buds offer nearly instantaneous translation across dozens of languages, so that it is theoretically possible to travel much of the world and converse with anyone who is similarly equipped, at least for basic conversations.

A variety of smartphone and smartwatch apps offer translation without the need for each party to have identical equipment; speakers take turns talking to the device and then listen as it outputs the translated speech. Microsoft's PowerPoint Presentation Translator adds real-time translation for presenters, making it easier for global professionals to connect with their audiences.

WHAT'S YOUR TAKE?

1. Do you think real-time translation, even if it gets close to the quality of human translators, will ever eliminate the need to learn other languages in order to communicate effectively with diverse, global audiences? Why or why not?
2. Find a partner who speaks another language and try one of these translation apps or services in a live conversation. How would you characterize the translation quality and the experience overall?

Sources: "Skype Translator," Skype, accessed 13 March 2019, www.skype.com; iTranslate Voice website, accessed 13 March 2019, itranslatevoice.com; "Presentation Translator," Microsoft, accessed 13 March 2019; Laura Cox, "Artificial Intelligence & Business Communication," *Disruption*, 22 May 2017, disruptionhub.com; Matthew Phenix, "Google Pixel Buds Review: What Travelers Need to Know," *Afar*, 24 September 2018, www.afar.com.

For important business meetings, consider using a professional interpreter.

For important meetings in which language might be a barrier, consider hiring an interpreter. The added expense could well be worth it to avoid misunderstandings and subtle language errors. The new generation of AI-enabled translating solutions can also be useful (see "Intelligent Communication Technology: Real-Time Translation" on the previous page).

HELPING OTHERS ADAPT TO YOUR CULTURE

Help others adapt to your culture; it will create a more productive workplace and teach you about their cultures as well.

Everyone can contribute to successful intercultural communication. Whether a younger person is unaccustomed to the formalities of a large corporation or a colleague from another country is working on a team with you, look for opportunities to help people fit in and adapt their communication style. For example, if a nonnative English speaker is making mistakes that could hurt his or her credibility, you can offer advice on the appropriate words and phrases to use. Most language learners truly appreciate this sort of assistance, as long as it is offered in a respectful manner. Moreover, chances are that while you're helping, you'll learn something about the other person's culture and language, too.

You can also take steps to simplify the communication process. For instance, oral communication in a second language is usually more difficult than written forms of communication, so instead of asking a foreign colleague to provide information in a conference call, you could ask for a written response instead of or in addition to the live conversation.

For a brief summary of ideas to improve intercultural communication in the workplace, see "Checklist: Improving Intercultural Communication Skills."

CHECKLIST ✓ Improving Intercultural Communication Skills

- Understand your own culture so that you can recognize its influences on your communication habits.
- Study other cultures so that you can appreciate cultural variations.
- Study the languages of people with whom you communicate, even if you can learn only a few basic words and phrases.
- Help nonnative speakers learn your language.
- Respect cultural preferences for communication style.
- Write clearly, using brief messages, simple language, generous transitions, and appropriate international conventions.
- Avoid slang, humor, and references to popular culture.
- Speak clearly and slowly, giving listeners time to translate your words.
- Ask for feedback to verify that communication was successful.
- Listen carefully and ask speakers to repeat anything you don't understand.

COMMUNICATION CHALLENGES AT Siemens AG

As leader of an international team in one of Siemens's Munich offices, you've learned to listen and adapt to different people and use your good intercultural skills to help resolve any problems of internal integration. How would you address the following challenges?

INDIVIDUAL CHALLENGE: Aleksei Petrikov joined your team six months ago as junior business analyst, just after graduation from university in Russia. He has a brilliant, analytical mind but resists working with other employees, even in team settings where collaboration is expected. Given the importance that you place on teamwork, how should you handle the situation? List several alternatives for addressing this dilemma. Identify which one you would choose, explaining why.

TEAM CHALLENGE: Some members of your team have recently begun breaking into various ethnic groups at lunch and company social events. These groups also occasionally chat in their native languages during the working day. You appreciate how this may give them a sense of community, but you worry that these informal communication channels will exclude and alienate other team members and fragment the flow of information. How can you encourage a stronger sense of community and teamwork across your department? Brainstorm at least three steps you can take to encourage better intercultural communication in your group.

Key Terms

cultural competency An appreciation for cultural differences that affect communication and the ability to adjust one's communication style to ensure that efforts to send and receive messages across cultural boundaries are successful

cultural context The pattern of physical cues, environmental stimuli, and implicit understanding that convey meaning between two members of the same culture

cultural pluralism The practice of accepting multiple cultures on their own terms

culture A shared system of symbols, beliefs, attitudes, values, expectations, and norms for behavior

diversity All the characteristics and experiences that define people as individuals

ethnocentrism The tendency to judge other groups according to the standards, behaviors, and customs of one's own group

high-context culture Culture in which people rely less on verbal communication and more on the context of nonverbal actions and environmental setting to convey meaning

idiomatic phrases Phrases or common sayings that mean more than the sum of their literal parts; such phrases can be difficult for nonnative speakers to understand

intercultural communication The process of sending and receiving messages between people whose cultural backgrounds could lead them to interpret verbal and nonverbal signs differently

low-context culture Culture in which people rely more on verbal communication and less on circumstances and nonverbal cues to convey meaning

stereotyping Assigning generalized attributes to an individual on the basis of membership in a particular culture or social group

xenophobia Fear of strangers and foreigners

Summary of Learning Objectives

1 Discuss the opportunities and challenges of intercultural communication. The global marketplace spans natural boundaries and national borders, allowing worldwide competition between businesses of all sizes. Therefore, today's businesspeople are likely to communicate across international borders with people who live in different cultures. Moreover, even domestic workforces are becoming more diverse, with employees having different national, religious, and ethnic backgrounds. In this environment, companies can benefit from a broad range of viewpoints and ideas, get a good understanding of diverse markets, and recruit workers from the broadest possible pool of talent. However, intercultural communication presents challenges as well, including motivating diverse employees to cooperate and to work together in teams as well as understanding enough about how culture affects language to prevent miscommunication.

2 Define cultural competency, and explain the influence of culture on business communication. Cultural competency includes an appreciation for cultural differences that affect communication and the ability to adjust one's communication style to ensure that efforts to send and receive messages across cultural boundaries are successful. Culture influences communication patterns and styles because members of a given culture tend to have similar assumptions about how people should think, behave, and communicate, and they tend to act on those assumptions in much the same way.

3 Explain the importance of recognizing cultural variations, and list eight key dimensions of cultural diversity. People from different cultures encode and decode messages differently, increasing the chances of misunderstanding. By recognizing and accommodating cultural differences, we avoid automatically assuming that everyone's thoughts and actions are just like ours. Begin by focusing on eight categories of differences: contextual differences (the degree to which a culture relies on verbal or nonverbal actions to convey meaning), legal and ethical differences (the degree to which laws and ethics are regarded and obeyed), social differences (how members value work and success, recognize status, define manners, and think about time), nonverbal differences (differing attitudes toward greetings, personal space, touching, facial expression, eye contact, posture, and formality), age differences (how members think about youth, seniority, and longevity), gender differences (how men and women communicate and the spectrum of gender identification), religious differences (how beliefs affect workplace relationships), and ability differences (inclusive strategies that enable people with disabilities to communicate more fully with the rest of the workforce).

4 List four general guidelines for adapting to any business culture. You can adapt to any business culture by (1) becoming aware of your own cultural biases so that you can understand how these forces shape your communication habits; (2) ignoring the Golden Rule (treating people the way you want them to treat you) and instead treating them the way *they* want to be treated; (3) exercising tolerance, flexibility, and respect; and (4) practicing patience and maintaining a sense of humor to get you through the bumpy spots.

5 Identify six steps you can take to improve your intercultural communication skills. Communicating successfully between cultures requires a variety of skills, all of which you can continue to improve throughout your career. Make your intercultural communication effective by (1) studying other cultures, (2) studying other languages, (3) respecting your audience's preferences for communication style, (4) writing as clearly as possible, (5) speaking and listening carefully, and (6) helping others adapt to your own culture.

Test Your Knowledge

To review chapter content related to each question, refer to the indicated Learning Objective.

3-1. What are the potential advantages of a diverse workforce? [LO-1]

3-2. What is cultural competency? [LO-2]

3-3. How is cultural pluralism a better option than cultural stereotyping? [LO-2]

3-4. What is ethnocentrism, and how can it be overcome in communication? [LO-2]
3-5. What are three habits that can help a person develop cultural pluralism? [LO-2]
3-6. How do high-context cultures differ from low-context cultures? [LO-3]
3-7. How will a patient approach help improve intercultural communication? [LO-4]
3-8. Why is it better to avoid slang terms, idioms, business jargon, and humor in intercultural communications? [LO-5]
3-9. How can the Golden Rule cause problems in intercultural communication? [LO-4]
3-10. What steps can you take to help someone from another culture adapt to your culture? [LO-5]

Apply Your Knowledge

To review chapter content related to each question, refer to the indicated Learning Objective.

3-11. To better understand how cultures can differ, even between close friends, find someone who lives close to you with whom you can discuss cultural differences. Create a list of similarities and differences between ways of taking vacations, family values (for example, living with different generations apart or together), attitudes toward the older generation, hours of work and times of work, formality at work, and level of respect accorded to supervisors. How do you think the most different items on your lists may cause both misunderstandings and possible conflicts between you and your friend? [LO-2]
3-12. Do the priorities in your list align with the culture's priorities? If not, how might this disparity affect your communication with other members of the culture? [LO-2]
3-13. How does making an effort to avoid assumptions contribute to the practice of cultural pluralism? [LO-3]
3-14. Why would it be better not to treat other people the way you would want to be treated? [LO-4]
3-15. How do you think different ethnocentric approaches to doing business might damage international trade? [LO-5]
3-16 How can helping someone adapt to your culture help you gain a better understanding of it yourself? [LO-5]

Practice Your Skills

Message for Analysis

3-17. **Message for Analysis: Adapting to Cultural Differences [LO-5]** You are working in a culturally diverse organization in Dubai. Recently, you received new, transferred employees from Jordan, Egypt, and Lebanon. Your boss wants to send an email to all recently transferred employees in your department. The employees understand English, but your boss asks you to review his message for clarity. What changes would you suggest to your boss and why? Would you consider this message to be audience centered? Why or why not? (Hint: Do some quick research on Dubai to identify the style of English that people from Jordan, Egypt, and Lebanon are likely to speak.) The email is as follows:

> I wanted to welcome you ASAP to our little family here in Dubai. It is high time we shook hands in person and not just across countries. I am pleased about getting to know you all, and I will do my level best to see you well in Dubai.

Exercises

Each activity is labeled according to the primary skill or skills you will need to use. To review relevant chapter content, you can refer to the indicated Learning Objective. In some instances, supporting information will be found in another chapter, as indicated.

3-18. Intercultural Communication: Recognizing Cultural Variations [LO-1], [LO-3], [LO-4] Review the generation labels on pages 119–120. Based on your year of birth, in which generation are you categorized? Do you feel a part of this generation? Why or why not? If you were born outside the United States, do the generational boundaries seem accurate to you? Now consider the biases that you might have regarding other generations. Identify several of your generational beliefs that could create friction in the workplace. Summarize your responses to these questions in a post on your class blog or an email message to your instructor.

3-19. Intercultural Communication: Adapting to Cultural Variations [LO-2] You are a new manager at K & J Brick, a masonry products company that is now run by the two sons of the man who founded it 50 years ago. For years, the co-owners have invited the management team to a wilderness lodge for a combination of outdoor sports and annual business planning meetings. You don't want to miss the event, but you know that the outdoor activities weren't designed for someone like you, whose physical impairments prevent participation in the sporting events. Draft a short email message to the rest of the management team, suggesting changes to the annual event that will allow all managers to participate.

3-20. Intercultural Communication: Writing for Multiple-Language Audiences [LO-5] Reading English-language content written by nonnative speakers of English can be a good reminder of the challenges of communicating in another language. The writing can be confusing or even amusing at first glance, but the key to remember here is that your writing might sound just as confusing or amusing to someone else if your roles were reversed.

Identify a company that is based in a non-English speaking country but that includes English-language text on its website. (The advanced search capabilities of your favorite search engine can help you locate websites from a particular country.) Study the language on this site. Does it sound as though it was written by someone adept at English? If the first site you find has writing that sounds natural to a native English speaker, find another company whose website doesn't. Select a section of text, at least several sentences long, and rewrite it to sound more "natural." Submit the original text and your rewritten version to your instructor.

3-21. Intercultural Communication: Writing for Multiple-Language Audiences; Collaboration: Team Projects [LO-5], Chapter 2 With a team assigned by your instructor, review the Facebook pages of five companies, looking for words and phrases that might be confusing to a nonnative speaker of English. If you (or someone on the team) are a nonnative speaker, explain to the team why those word choices could be confusing. Choose three sentences, headlines, company slogans, or other pieces of text that contain potentially confusing words and rewrite them to minimize the chances of misinterpretation. Try to retain the tone of the original—although you may find that doing so is impossible in some instances. Compile the original selections and your revised versions and then email the documents to your instructor.

3-22. Intercultural Communication: Speaking with Multiple-Language Audiences; Collaboration: Team Projects [LO-5], Chapter 2 Seek two colleagues or friends, ideally those who speak different first languages, one person of whom speaks the local language. Then find a local newspaper article about 200 words long. Work together to change the article into simple language that you all understand and then present the original article and your new simplified version to your class. When making your presentation, ensure that you explain all the idioms and native expressions used in the original article, showing how you have simplified each one.

3-23. Intercultural Communication: Speaking with Multiple-Language Audiences; Media Skills: Podcasting [LO-5], Chapter 7 Your company was one of the first to use podcasting as a business communication tool. Executives frequently record messages (such as monthly sales summaries) and post them on the company's intranet site; employees from the 14 offices in Europe, Asia, and North America then download the files to their music players or other devices and listen to the messages while riding the train to work, exercising, and so on. Your boss asks you to draft the opening statement for a podcast that will announce a revenue drop caused by intensive competitive pressure. She reviews your script and hands it back with a gentle explanation that it needs to be revised for international listeners. Improve the following statement in as many ways as you can:

> Howdy, comrades. Shouldn't surprise anyone that we took a beating this year, given the insane pricing moves our knucklehead competitors have been making. I mean, how those clowns can keep turning a profit is beyond me, what with steel costs still going through the roof and labor costs heating up—even in countries where everybody goes to find cheap labor—and hazardous waste disposal regs adding to operating costs, too.

Expand Your Skills

Critique the Professionals

Find an online business document—such as a company website, blog post, Facebook page, or LinkedIn profile—that you believe commits an intercultural communication blunder by failing to consider the needs of at least some of its target readers. For example, a website might use slang or idiomatic language that could confuse some readers, or it might use language that offends some readers. In a post on your class blog, share the text you found, and explain why you think it does not succeed as effective intercultural communication. Be sure to include a link to the original material.

Sharpening Your Career Skills Online

Find a website, video, article, podcast, or presentation that offers advice on communicating with business contacts in another country or culture. Write a brief email message to your instructor describing the item you found and summarizing the career skills information you learned from it.

Build Your Career

In the Build Your Career exercises in Chapters 1 and 2, you looked at what you want to do in your career and what you have to offer employers and clients. Now it's time to explore ways to make yourself more valuable. You can divide this effort into two key parts: expanding your skill set and increasing your knowledge.

If you are already working, look for opportunities to take on new challenges that will develop valuable skills. For example, you might offer to mentor a new employee or search for ways to reduce operating costs. If you aren't in the professional workforce yet, look for volunteering, school activities, or project gigs to develop new skills. Even if these opportunities don't offer the specific *hard skills* (the technical aspects of a job) your future career requires, they often let you develop *soft skills* such as leadership, collaboration, and communication.

While you are developing skills, learn as much as you can about the professions you might join and the industries and companies in which you might work. Use Twitter, LinkedIn, Facebook, and YouTube to find and follow experts. You can get a feel for the big issues in a profession or an industry, start to grasp the insider jargon, and get a sense of what it is like to work in these careers. Employers look for candidates who show curiosity and industry knowledge, so you'll be giving yourself a big advantage in competing for the best jobs.

As you gain skills and knowledge, maintain lists of what you can do and what you have learned. This "professional inventory" will be the foundation of your personal branding effort (see the Build Your Career activities starting in Chapter 4) and your résumé and other employment communication efforts.

Endnotes

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